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bills can be reduced simply by switching off the power to computers and other electronics such as cellphone chargers.

3. Tweak the computer's power management for optimum savings. We're often away from our screens — coffee breaks, telephone calls, and numerous other distractions always keep popping up to pull you away from your desk. Screen savers that usually kick in at such times won't save your screens and won't do much for your power bills either. Keep the settings such that your monitor switches off after five minutes, or less, of being idle.

Cut your phone bills

Cutting down on phone costs can be a tricky business considering the multitude of offers and plans out there. The key is to analyse your usage pattern.

1. Find out what type of calls your business is required make — whether more calls will go out to cell phones or to land lines — whether STD or local?

2. Find out from where most of the calling happens — whether land lines or mobiles? Once you know, choose a plan and service provider to meet your requirements.

3. An increasing number of people are saving money by using Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) clients, such as Skype. While the quality of service varies, it can be more cost-effective than landlines. Skype can be used to make international as well as domestic internet calls. While international calls are charged a nominal amount, the domestic calls are free (Check the box 'Setting up Skype' for details on how to install and use Skype). There are software such as TeamSpeak which will allow you to host a voice-chat server for multiple users to log into. So conference calls within the same building or even branch offices can be achieved.

4. If you have a number of employees working and you're not constantly around to supervise, it's probably a good idea to keep STD active on only some lines. Phone lock codes are also a good idea.

5. Use free SMS services such as www.way2sms.com. After all, a penny saved is a penny earned.

Cut your internet costs

Internet costs for your office can be brought down through some tweaking.

1. Analyse your usage pattern. Is it more of just email and light browsing, or is a fair bit of downloading required? If it is the former, we'd recommend going in for speed and bandwidth as against high-data limits. Any 256kbps connection these days offers 500MB of data transfer. This is more than sufficient for browsing and email. The bandwidth,

too, is good enough to give you decent browsing speeds when split into say three PCs over a network. Firewalls and filters are a must unless you want your employees to be loitering around on Orkut and using up precious bandwidth and data limits. If you're on a limited data line, you need to have a caching server / proxy, so that frequently visited web pages are stored on local drives for quick retrieval. This means that these web pages are not downloaded each and every time you visit them (Check the box 'Cutting internet costs' to learn how).

2. If your usage is more download-intensive, opt for the unlimited plans. Any good unlimited plan these days should be not be more than Rs. 1,500 for a 256kbps line.

3. These days, for most businesses, however small, having a web site is a must. Accordingly, many small businesses do host simple web sites, for which they end up paying a lot of money as domain registration charges and web space. While in fact web space is available for cheap

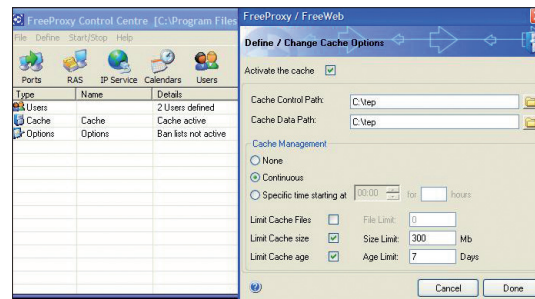
and at times, at zero cost. You should not pay more than Rs. 450 for domain registration. If your web site is hosted by one of those web space resellers that sprouted at every corner during the dot-com boom, then please look elsewhere. Host your website on, freewebspace.com or at least paid,

but cheaper Indian servers. Once your domain is registered, all you need to do is redirect it to where your web site is hosted. For example, buy the domain www.yourbusiness.com but host it at <http://yourbusiness.freewebspace.com>.

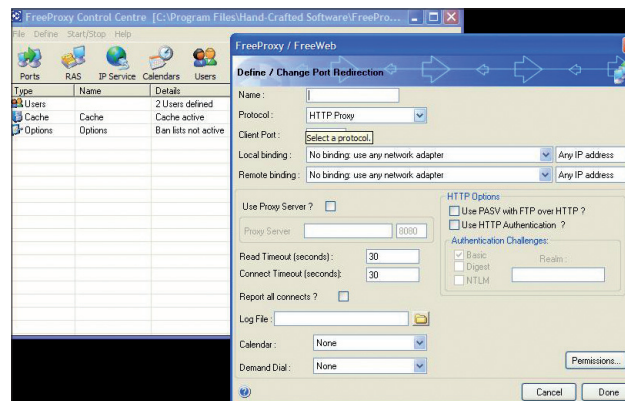
4. The same goes for email. If your friendly neighbourhood web space reseller is charging you for an email interface, you need to stop right away. Zoho.com has solutions for small office users, whereby your emails are pulled to Zoho's servers. You get the Zoho interface that is quite similar to Gmail and migration is also pretty straight forward. The best part — it's free for up to ten users! All you need to do is configure your domain and

e-mail information with Zoho. Your email will remain you@yourbusiness.com, but you'll now be checking mails at something like <http://business.mail.zoho.com/a/your-business.com/#inbox>.

Google also offers a similar service, and they're trying to hide it. Go to www.google.com/a/, click the big blue "See details and sign up" button. Although it looks



Free Proxy: Setting up caching



FreeProxy: Setting up the proxy server